

TANTRAYA

Supplementary Workbook · The Ten Mahavidyas

Dhumavati

She Who Is Made of Smoke



Dhumavati, the widow goddess, seated in her crow-bannered cart

Seventh of the Mahavidyas · The Uprooting

The widow, the smoke, Shakti without Shiva

Direct contact with loss, invisibility, and disgust

Tantraya · Sacred Valley of Peru

At a Glance

RANK	Seventh of the ten Mahavidyas
NAME MEANS	“She who is made of smoke,” from dhūma, smoke, and vatī, one who carries or possesses
FORM	An old, thin widow with pale or ashen skin, unkempt hair, no jewellery, plain or worn cloth
VEHICLE / EMBLEMS	A crowless chariot or crow emblem, and a winnowing basket
KARMA / ACTION	Uccāṭana, uprooting: removing something entirely from where it has taken root
FOCUS OF THESE PRACTICES	Direct contact with loss, invisibility, and disgust, without reaching for a story that softens it

The Myth

Two accounts of her origin exist side by side, and both are worth knowing.

The first: when Sati burned herself alive at her father Daksha’s sacrifice, rather than see her husband Shiva excluded and dishonoured, what rose from that fire was smoke, grief with no shape left to hold it. Dhumavati is what remained of Sati after everything that could burn had burned. She is sometimes described simply as “all that is left of Sati.”

The second account is stranger. Sati, overcome with hunger while Shiva sat deep in meditation, asked him repeatedly for food. He kept telling her to wait. Eventually her hunger became so total that she swallowed Shiva himself. Smoke began rising from within her, Shiva’s own ascetic fire, still burning even inside her. Shiva asked to be released, and, ashamed at what she had done, she brought him back up. He then told her that having consumed her own husband, she would take the form of a widow from that point on.

Symbolism and Image

Nothing about Dhumavati is designed to be wanted. Every other Mahavidya carries some version of beauty, wealth, fierce power, or intensity that draws the eye toward her.

Dhumavati is built the opposite way: old, ashen, unadorned, trembling, without a single ornament. This is not an accident of the tradition or a mark of lesser status. It is the entire point. She removes anything a practitioner might reach for out of attraction, so that what is left has to be met on its own terms.

The widow status carries real weight in the culture this material comes from, where a widow historically had no husband to derive status or security from and no expectation of remarriage. Read that way, Dhumavati is a figure standing entirely outside the structure that normally defines and protects a woman in that world: outside relationship, outside role, outside the usual sources of safety. Some traditions describe her directly as Shakti without Shiva, the feminine, generative power of the universe, present even when the force it is usually paired with and defined against is entirely absent.

The winnowing basket she carries is a farming tool used to separate grain from husk by throwing both into the air and letting the wind carry off what is not needed. It is a precise image for what her practices actually ask of a student: seeing clearly what is substantial and what was never anything more than covering. The crow, considered inauspicious in ordinary Hindu symbolism and closely tied to death ritual and ancestor offerings, appears here too. She keeps company with exactly what most worship tries to keep at a comfortable distance.

Understanding the Energy

Within the tantric classification of six ritual actions a practitioner can direct outward, pacifying, attracting, immobilizing, dividing, uprooting, and destroying, Dhumavati is specifically linked to uprooting, *uccāṭana*: the removal of something from where it has taken root. Where Bagalamukhi's *stambhana* freezes something in place, Dhumavati's domain takes it out entirely, leaving nothing behind for it to grow back from.



The six karmas: Dhumavati's domain is uccāṭana, the uprooting

What makes her genuinely difficult, and genuinely valuable, is that she does not resolve into anything comforting. Most spiritual material, even material that deals honestly with loss or fear, tends to arrive somewhere reassuring by the end: a lesson learned, a meaning found, a silver lining. Dhumavati offers none of that. She is what is left when meaning-making has stopped working and you are simply sitting with what is actually there. That is a real capacity, and a rare one, and it is the specific thing these practices are designed to develop.

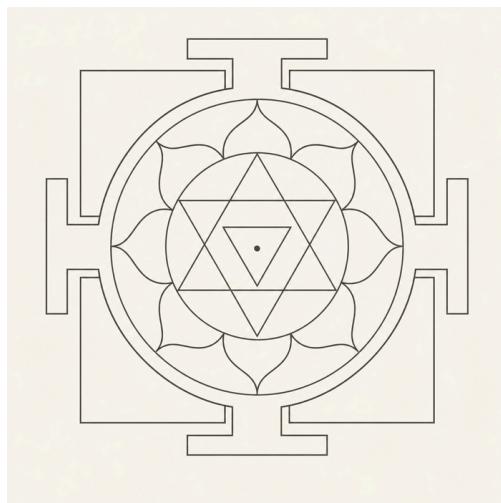
How to Work With These Practices

Most people spend real energy avoiding exactly what Dhumavati represents: being unseen, growing old, losing what they have built an identity around, feeling disgust without immediately explaining it away.

These practices have one method. Direct contact, without flinching and without reaching for a story that makes it easier to bear. Do not try to fix it, transform it, or make sense of it. Stay with it, plainly, for the length of the practice.

Expect this to be one of the harder passages in this material. Expect it, afterward, to be one you value most.

Practices



The Dhumavati Yantra: a triangle of dissolution set within the bhupura and lotus

Dhumavati is not built around a technique. She is built around a willingness: the willingness to remain in contact with what is actually here, loss, age, disgust, invisibility, without reaching for a story that makes any of it easier to carry.

Everything below is one continuous exercise in that willingness, laid out across seven days so it can be entered gradually instead of all at once. Do not try to feel better by the end of it. That is not the aim, and it is not usually what happens. What tends to happen instead is a kind of ground appearing under a person that was not there before, one that does not depend on things going well.

Practice One – What the Eye Skips Over

Practice. Spend the day noticing what you and everyone around you habitually look away from: the older person nobody addresses directly, the beggar, the smell of decay, the visibly unwell. Do not intervene, comment, or fix anything. Simply let your attention land on what usually gets skipped, and stay there a few extra seconds each time before moving on.

Evening reflection. What did I look away from today, and what happened in my body the moment before I looked away?

Practice Two – Dressing Down

Practice. Wear the plainest, most worn clothing you own. Do nothing to manage how you are perceived: no posting, no curated photos, no effort toward being found attractive, capable, or impressive in any interaction. Let people form whatever impression they form.

Evening reflection. Where did I feel the pull to correct someone's impression of me, and what was I afraid that impression meant?

Practice Three – The Winnowing

Practice. Choose three things you currently rely on for a sense of worth, appearance, achievement, possessions, other people's opinion, and for one day act as though each of them had been removed. Notice, honestly, what is left standing under you when they are gone even for a day.

Evening reflection. When I imagined each one gone, what in me stayed exactly the same?

Practice Four – Working Without “I”

Practice. Outside of necessary work speech, avoid the words “I,” “me,” and “mine” for the entire day. Notice how much of ordinary speech is built to place yourself at the center of the sentence, and notice what happens in you once that placement is no longer available.

Evening reflection. How much quieter did I become once I could not keep returning the conversation to myself?

Practice Five – Direct Contact With Decay

Practice. Cut open an apple or a banana and set it where you will see it daily; do not discard it, let it decay naturally over the coming days and observe it each time you pass. If you are able, spend an hour at a cemetery, walking slowly, reading names and dates, and let yourself feel, rather than merely picture, your own body moving through the same stages.

Evening reflection. What did I do, today, to avoid thinking about my own death, and what happened when I stopped doing it?

Practice Six – Sitting With Disgust

Practice. Choose something that provokes real disgust in you and look directly at it rather than turning away, holding your attention there until the first wave of reaction passes. Trace the feeling to what is actually underneath it: fear of contamination, fear of mortality, fear of losing status. Separately, look at photographs of a person widely considered beautiful when they were young, then photographs of the same person decades later, and watch your own reaction to both without editing it.

Evening reflection. What did disgust turn out to be protecting me from, once I stopped flinching from it?

Practice Seven – Shakti Without Shiva

Practice. Sit for twenty minutes with the plain fact that everything you currently hold, relationships, health, roles, will end. Do not soften this into a lesson about appreciating the present. Let it simply be true, the way Dhumavati is simply what remains once the fire has finished burning. Ask directly: what in me does not require Shiva, structure, partner, role, recognition, to still be standing.

Evening reflection. What in me was never actually dependent on any of what I spent these practices imagining I could not survive without?

Advanced Exercises

The Uninvited Guest. For one ordinary interaction each day this practice, deliberately withhold the impulse to be liked, helpful, witty, or impressive. Simply be present and plain. Notice how strong the pull toward performance actually is once you try to set it down.

The Discarded Object. Find an object you own that is worn out, chipped, or unfashionable and use it deliberately in front of others rather than hiding it. Notice the discomfort, and notice that the discomfort is the entire practice.

Sitting in the Ash. At the end of it, sit quietly with a small dish of cold ash or cooled cigarette ash, or simply the memory of a fire that has gone out, and let it stand for everything these practices asked you to meet directly. Make no attempt to feel better about it.

The Deeper Principle

Every other Mahavidya offers a practitioner something to move toward: power, wisdom, protection, pleasure, victory. Dhumavati offers nothing to move toward. She asks a much stranger question: who are you when there is nothing left to move toward, and nothing left to be seen doing it.

This is why traditional practitioners describe her as inauspicious, and why most worship keeps a respectful distance from her. She does not reward. She removes, uccāṭana, uprooting, and what she uproots is usually the very thing a person had quietly built their sense of self around. That removal is not cruelty. It is closer to an X-ray: revealing what was structural and what was only decoration.

A student who has genuinely sat through these practices with Dhumavati does not come out of it feeling better in any ordinary sense. They come out of it able to stand in loss, invisibility, and disgust without immediately needing an exit. That capacity, once it is actually present in a nervous system, does not disappear. It becomes available in every later grief, every later season of being unseen, every later encounter with what repels.

Her Faculty

If each Mahavidya develops one irreplaceable human capacity, Dhumavati's is the capacity to remain present without reward. Call it unadorned presence: the ability to stay, clear-eyed and unflinching, in exactly the conditions that most people, and most spiritual paths, are quietly organized around avoiding.

It is not resignation, and it is not detachment in the passive sense the word often implies. It is closer to what remains standing once every ordinary reason to keep standing has been removed. That is Dhumavati's gift, offered, as always, without ornament.